

Road to recovery is paved with L.A. fire relief

Donations surpass \$650 million as vital nonprofits map out strategy for assistance.

By Harriet Ryan

When wildfires swept through Los Angeles, people and corporations from around the world responded by opening their wallets in a way that broke records for generosity.

Money poured into thousands of different recipients, from venerable nonprofits such as the United Way and Habitat for Humanity, to individual families through GoFundMe, to specialized groups working to replace burned musical instruments and stuffed animals.

The array of organizations makes a precise tally of the philanthropic dollars challenging, but the amount raised and pledged over the last month is well in excess of \$650 million, according to interviews with nonprofit executives and publicly announced fundraising efforts.

That appears to set a fundraising record for wildfires and exceeds giving for recent natural disasters. Charitable contributions for Maui's deadly 2023 fire totaled about \$450 million, according to a database compiled by Honolulu Civil Beat. Fundraising for Hurricanes Milton and Helene, which devastated the southeastern U.S. last year, topped \$278 million, according a partial tabulation by the philanthropy site Candid.

The charitable outpouring for the January fires reflects the scale of destruction in the Palisades and the Altadena area, the connection people far from California feel to L.A. and Hollywood, and celebrities' place as both survivors and fundraisers.

Musicians on the Feb. 2 Grammy Awards broadcast appealed for donations. Billie Eilish, Stevie Wonder, the Red Hot Chili Peppers and [See Donations, A7]



FRANK BROWN Los Angeles Times

OFFICIALS in February 1962 examine the remains of homes destroyed by the Bel-Air fire three months earlier.

A failure to learn from mistakes

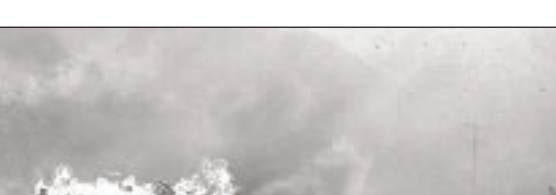
On a hot, dry November morning in 1961, flames from a trash pile on brushland north of Mulholland Drive were picked up by Santa Ana winds and swept across the canyons of one of Los Angeles' wealthiest enclaves.

The apocalyptic scenes that played out — of Hollywood celebrities fleeing and clambering onto their roofs — captured the world's attention like no urban conflagration in history. Actor Kim Novak and Richard Nixon, then a former vice president who moved to L.A. to practice law, wielded garden hoses to soak their wooden roof shingles. Actor Fred MacMurray enlisted studio workers from the set of "My Three Sons" to evacuate his family and help firefighters cut down brush around his Brentwood home.

When the blaze reached the mansions of Bel-Air, thermal heat lifted burning shingles high into the air and 50-mph winds hurled them more

than a mile over to Brentwood. By nightfall, the Bel-Air fire had destroyed 484 homes, including those of actor Burt Lancaster, comedian Joe E. Brown and Nobel laureate chemist Willard Libby.

After firefighters extinguished the flames, socialite and actor Zsa Zsa Gabor, wearing white kitten heels and a string of pearls as she clutched a shovel, dug through the rubble of her Belagio Place home for a safe with jewels.



Los Angeles Times

FIREFIGHTERS stand by as a Roscomare Road home burns during the Bel-Air fire Nov. 6, 1961.

The Bel-Air fire became known as the "the big one," the event that forced everyone in Los Angeles to reckon with the dangers fire posed to their coveted hillsides.

In response, L.A. officials ushered in new fire safety measures, investing in more firefighting helicopters, new fire stations and a new reservoir. They also outlawed untreated wood shingles in high-fire-risk areas and initiated a

[See Fire history, A6]

Musk team's access blocked

Judge issues injunction in Treasury data case, shielding sensitive personal information of millions. **NATION, A4**

ICE plans sweep in the L.A. area

FBI and DEA agents are asked to join "large scale" operation this month, sources say. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Our expert's pick, FWIW

Bill Plaschke admits his Super Bowl predictions aren't great, but says the Eagles will fly to victory. **SPORTS, D1**

Weather

Variable cloudiness. L.A. Basin: 70/46. **B10**

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ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

THIS prefabricated home recently went up on private land within Joshua Tree National Park. The prospect of more development has alarmed environmentalists.

Mysterious land deals spur worry

Buyers' plans unclear for parcels surrounded by park

By Alex Wigglesworth and Lila Seidman

JOSHUA TREE NATIONAL PARK, Calif. — The vistas are sprawling and unspoiled. Mountains rim

blue-sky horizons, and scrub brush scattered across the rocky desert hills sustain mule deer, bighorn sheep and other wildlife.

Known as Whispering Pines, this roughly 2-square-mile wildland within the

boundaries of Joshua Tree National Park was once dotted with rustic vacation cabins. Most are gone now, wiped away by wildfire, floodwaters or simply the passage of time, making it a [See Joshua Tree, A8]

2 trans athletes on front lines of a raging debate

A runner and a pole vaulter describe the polarization at their Riverside high school.

By Kevin Rector

When M.L. walks the halls of her Riverside high school, the fact that her life is the subject of a swirling national debate is never far from mind. It's spelled out on the T-shirts of kids all around her.

"SAVE GIRLS SPORTS," read some. "WE'RE ALL EQUAL," read others.

The dueling shirts provide a stark visual of what her schoolmates think about her competing on the

girls' cross-country and track teams. It's made her feel both proud and anxious, she said — and a bit like being in a fishbowl.

"A lot of people have said things, both good and bad," said M.L., who is 16 and transgender. She asked to be identified only by initials because of the threats young athletes like her have faced nationwide. "It's nerve-racking."

Individual school hallways, sports fields and tracks like those at Martin Luther King High School in Riverside, which M.L. attends, are the real front lines in the nation's contentious battle over transgender athletes.

More than the White House, where President [See Athletes, A10]



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